

SOUND FOR VIDEO

Fix Your Audio

Clean, Professional Sound for Any Video

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What's Inside

Clean, Professional Sound for Any Video. Written for creators whose picture is fine but the sound lets them down.

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Bad Audio Is the Fastest Way to Lose a Viewer

People will forgive a soft-focus shot, a shaky handheld pan, even a slightly blown-out sky. They will not forgive sound they have to strain to understand. The instant a video sounds hollow, hissy, or echoey, the brain reads it as "amateur" and the thumb reaches for the next thing. This guide teaches you to record clean, clear, professional sound with whatever you already own.

Here is the truth nobody tells beginners: **audio is half of video, and it is the half you can actually control.** You can't move the sun, but you can move a microphone. And almost every "why does my sound suck" problem traces back to just three culprits — the mic is too far away, the room is fighting you, or your levels are set wrong. Learn to spot those three and you fix bad sound at the source instead of trying to rescue it later.

Nobody clicks away thinking "the signal-to-noise ratio is poor." They click away thinking "this feels cheap."

Clear speech feels effortless to listen to, and effortless reads as competent. The moment a listener has to work — leaning in, rewinding, guessing at a word — a small alarm goes off that says "this creator didn't have it together." That alarm fires even when the viewer can't name what's wrong. They just feel it and leave. The flip side is the opportunity: because audio is judged so harshly, it's also the fastest quality upgrade available to you. A modest camera with clean, close, well-leveled sound looks more professional than an expensive camera with echoey phone audio.

THE WHOLE GUIDE IN ONE SENTENCE

Great sound comes from getting the right mic close to the mouth, taming the room, and setting levels you can hear in headphones — everything else is polish.

The three things that ruin sound



Distance

The mic is too far from the mouth, so the voice is thin and buried under everything else in the room.



The Room

Bare walls bounce sound back as echo and reverb. Your voice arrives at the mic three times — direct, then two ghosts.



Levels

Recorded too quiet and you amplify hiss later; too hot and it clips into permanent distortion.

How to use this guide

If your sound is broken right now, read Chapter 4 (get the mic close) and Chapter 6 (levels) first — they fix the majority of problems by tonight. Then work through the rest to make good sound repeatable. The final chapter is a printable pre-roll checklist; keep it on your phone.



Gear-agnostic on purpose

Everything here works with a phone, a mirrorless camera, a DSLR, or a dedicated recorder. Where a mic type has different names, we say so. You do not need expensive gear to sound professional — you need the right kind of mic in the right place at the right level.



The blind test

Close your eyes and listen to your last video. If you'd assume it was made by a beginner, so does your audience. Your ears are the only quality meter that matters — start trusting them.

CHAPTER 1

Why Your Built-in Mic Fails

The mic in your camera or phone isn't broken — it's just doing an impossible job from the wrong place. Once you understand the two reasons it can't win, you'll never be surprised by hollow sound again.

Reason one: it's too far away

Sound obeys the **inverse-square law** — every time you double the distance from a sound source, the loudness drops to roughly a quarter. A mic on your camera sitting six feet from your subject is receiving a voice that's a fraction of the strength a mic six inches away would get. To hear the distant voice at all, the camera cranks up its gain — and that same gain amplifies the air conditioner, the room echo, and the electronic hiss right alongside the words.

THE DISTANCE PRINCIPLE

It is not that a close mic is "louder." It is that a close mic captures far more voice relative to everything else — which is the entire game.

Reason two: it hears everything

Built-in mics are usually **omnidirectional** — they pick up sound equally from all directions. That's great for capturing a whole scene and terrible for capturing one person, because it treats the traffic behind you and the voice in front of you as equally important. A good external mic is *directional*: it listens hard where you point it and ignores the rest.

Pickup pattern, in plain terms

A pickup pattern is simply the shape of what a mic "hears." Picture it as an invisible zone of sensitivity around the mic:

● **Omnidirectional**

Hears a full sphere — every direction equally. Built-in mics and many lavaliers. Natural, but grabs the whole room.

♥ **Cardioid**

Hears mostly the front, rejects the rear. The workhorse pattern for a single person talking. USB and desktop mics live here.

Supercardioid / Shotgun

A tight forward beam that rejects the sides. Reaches a bit farther and isolates one source — the interview and film standard.

Bidirectional

Hears front and back, rejects the sides. Useful for two people facing each other across one mic.



A directional mic is not a zoom lens

A shotgun mic *rejects* off-axis sound better than a wide pattern, but it does not "reach across the room." Even the tightest shotgun still sounds best a foot or two from the mouth. Directionality reduces the room; it does not replace closeness.

CHAPTER 2

Mic Types & When to Use Each

There is no single "best microphone" — there's the right tool for how you shoot. Here are the four categories that cover almost everything a video creator does, and exactly when to reach for each.

Mic type	Best for	Pattern	Watch out for
Lavalier (clip-on / lav)	Interviews, talking-head, run-and-gun, moving subjects	Omni or cardioid	Clothing rustle; being visible in frame
Shotgun (on-camera or boomed)	Interviews, scenes, dialogue you want off-camera	Supercardioid	Room echo if too far; wind outdoors
USB / desktop	Voiceover, tutorials, podcasts, seated to-camera	Cardioid	Desk thumps; not portable; picks up room
Phone-connected (wireless or plug-in)	Mobile creators, vlogs, quick social clips	Omni (lav) or cardioid	Adapters/compatibility; battery life

Lavalier microphones

A tiny mic that clips near the collar, six to eight inches from the mouth. Because it's always close and moves with the person, it's the most forgiving choice for anyone who talks and moves. Wireless lav systems free your subject from cables; wired lavs are cheaper and never drop out.

Shotgun microphones

A long, narrow mic with a tight forward pattern. Mounted on the camera it's convenient; on a boom pole or stand just outside the frame, angled down at the mouth, it sounds cinematic. This is what most film and interview work uses.

USB and desktop microphones

Plug straight into a computer for voiceover, tutorials, and podcasts. Large-diaphragm cardioid mics sound rich up close. They're not built to travel, but for a seated creator at a desk they're the easiest path to a full, professional voice.

Phone-connected microphones

Small wireless transmitters or plug-in mics designed for phones and mirrorless cameras. Modern wireless lav kits are astonishingly good for the size and have become the default for mobile creators and vloggers.



If you buy one mic

For most creators, a **wireless lavalier kit** is the highest-impact purchase — it guarantees a close mic on the person talking, works on phones and cameras, and handles both interviews and run-and-gun. If you shoot seated tutorials only, buy a cardioid USB mic instead.

CHAPTER 3

The Golden Rule — Get the Mic Close

If you remember nothing else from this guide, remember this chapter. Ninety percent of "professional versus amateur" sound is a single variable: **how far the microphone is from the mouth**. Close mic = strong voice, quiet room, low noise. Far mic = thin voice swimming in echo and hiss. Everything else is a rounding error next to distance.

THE GOLDEN RULE

Get the microphone as close to the mouth as you can without it being in the shot or in the way — then get it a little closer.

Placement by scenario

Interview (seated, off-camera mic)

STARTING POINT

Mic type **Shotgun or lav**

Distance **6-18 in**

Angle **Toward mouth**

Boom a shotgun from above, angled down at the mouth, just out of frame — or clip a lav six to eight inches below the chin. Aim at the mouth, not the chest.

Talking-head (to camera, seated)

STARTING POINT

Mic type **USB or lav**

Distance **6-12 in**

Position **Below, off-axis**

Place a desktop mic just below the frame line, angled up at the mouth. Speaking slightly across it (off-axis) softens hard plosives on words like "p" and "b".

Run-and-gun / vlog (moving)

STARTING POINT

Mic type **Wireless lav**

Distance **6-8 in**

Backup **Camera scratch track**

Clip the lav high on the chest. Let the camera's own mic record a rough "scratch" track too — it's a lifesaver for syncing and as a backup if the wireless drops.



Lav placement without rustle

Clip the lav where fabric won't brush it — a lapel, collar edge, or placket, not the middle of a shifting shirt. Loop the cable into a small "P" shape and tape it to the back of the clip so cable tension never tugs the capsule. Route the wire under clothing to hide it.



Beware the plosive blast

Aiming a mic straight at the mouth from a few inches away turns every "p" and "b" into a thump of air. Position the mic slightly off to the side or below, so that burst of breath passes *across* the capsule rather than into it. A foam windscreen helps too.

CHAPTER 4

Tame the Room

You've got the mic close — but if the space is fighting you, the voice still arrives with a hollow, boxy, distant quality. That's **reverb**: your voice bouncing off hard surfaces and reaching the mic again a few milliseconds late, over and over. Small rooms with bare walls are the worst offenders, and it's the single hardest thing to remove later. Fix it at the source.

Why bare rooms sound bad

Sound waves bounce off anything hard and flat — drywall, windows, tile floors, empty desks. Each bounce is a copy of your voice arriving late, smearing clarity into an echoey wash. Soft, irregular surfaces absorb those waves instead of reflecting them. A room that sounds bad is simply a room with too many hard, parallel surfaces and nothing soft to soak up the energy.

The clap test

Stand where you'll record and clap once, sharply. If you hear a ring, a slap, or a little "boing" trailing off, the room is reflective and your voice will too. Clap in a closet full of clothes — that dead, instant thud is what you're aiming for. Treat the room until the clap dies fast.

Cheap treatment that actually works

- ☒ Record in the room with the most soft stuff — a bedroom beats a kitchen or garage.
- ☒ Add soft mass: hang blankets, put up curtains, lay down a rug, fill bookshelves.
- ☒ Break up big flat walls behind and beside you; those are the worst reflectors.
- ☒ Get close to the mic — a close mic captures more direct voice and less reflected room automatically.
- ☒ Avoid the center of an empty room; corners and soft-furnished areas are friendlier.
- ☒ For voiceover in a pinch, drape a blanket over yourself and the mic like a tent.



Closeness is free room treatment

Doubling your distance from the mic doesn't just weaken the voice — it strengthens the room's share of what's recorded. Every inch closer tilts the balance toward direct sound and away from reverb. Before you buy a single acoustic panel, close the gap between the mic and the mouth.

CHAPTER 5

Set Levels & Monitor

You can have the perfect mic in the perfect spot and still ruin the take with the wrong level. Audio is measured in **dBFS** (decibels relative to full scale), a negative scale where 0 dBFS is the absolute ceiling — the loudest a digital recording can hold. Go over it and the waveform slams into that wall and distorts. The whole job is to record strong, but never touch the ceiling.

Your target: peaks around -12 to -6 dBFS

Aim for the loudest parts of speech to peak somewhere between **-12 and -6 dBFS**, with your average voice sitting lower, around -18 to -12. That leaves comfortable *headroom* — a safety gap above your peaks — so an unexpected laugh or emphasized word doesn't clip. Watch the meters as you do a test line at your real speaking volume, and set the gain so the peaks land in that zone.

Level targets

DIGITAL AUDIO

Peaks -12 to -6 dBFS

Average -18 to -12 dBFS

Ceiling 0 dBFS (never touch)

Headroom keep 6 dB+

Set gain with a real test line at your true volume — not a timid "test, test." People get louder once they're rolling.



Clipping is permanent

When audio hits 0 dBFS it doesn't just get loud — the peaks are sliced flat and the information is **gone**. No plugin, no AI, nothing brings it back; it will always sound like harsh crackling distortion. When in doubt, record a little quieter. A quiet clean take can be turned up. A clipped take is trash.

Always monitor with headphones

This is the habit that separates people who get clean sound from people who get surprised by it. Your eyes on a meter tell you the level; only your ears in headphones tell you the *quality* — the wireless dropout, the clothing rustle, the AC that kicked on, the buzz from a bad cable. Meters can't hear those. You can.

THE ONE NON-NEGOTIABLE HABIT

If you cannot hear the recording live in headphones, you are not recording sound — you are gambling on it.



Confirm you're hearing the mic, not the room

Plug headphones into the device that's actually recording and confirm you hear the microphone's signal through them, not just ambient sound leaking past the earcups. If it's silent in the phones, the mic isn't getting to the recorder — better to find out now than in the edit.

CHAPTER 6

Recording Options & Syncing

Where the sound actually lands — inside the camera, on a separate recorder, or both — shapes your whole workflow. Here's how to choose, and how to marry sound back to picture when they're recorded apart.

Three ways to capture



In-camera

Mic plugs into the camera; sound and picture record together. Simplest — nothing to sync. Limited by the camera's audio circuitry and monitoring.



External recorder

Mic feeds a dedicated audio recorder. Better preamps, better metering, real headphone monitoring. You'll sync to picture later.



Dual-system

Record sound externally *and* a scratch track in-camera. The pro standard: best quality plus an easy sync reference and a backup.

In-camera

The easiest path: everything's already together, and for talking-head and vlog work it's often all you need. Just confirm your camera lets you monitor with headphones and set levels manually — auto-gain circuits pump the noise floor up and down and should be turned off when possible.

External recorder & dual-system

Recording to a separate device gives you cleaner preamps and proper monitoring, at the cost of syncing sound to picture in the edit. The professional move is **dual-system**: record the good audio externally while also letting the camera capture a rough scratch track. That scratch track is what you'll sync against, and it saves the day if the main recording ever fails.

Getting sound and picture in sync

1

Clap or slate at the top of every take.

A sharp clap (or a slate/clapperboard) makes a spike in the audio and a single frame where hands meet in video — line those up and everything after is locked.

2**Or let software auto-sync.**

Most editors can match the external audio to the camera's scratch track by analyzing the waveforms — which is exactly why you always record that scratch track.

3**Check sync on a hard consonant.**

After aligning, watch a "p" or "b" or a clap and confirm lips and sound hit together. If it drifts over a long take, re-sync at the drift point.

**The clap is free insurance**

Even when you plan to auto-sync, clap anyway. It costs one second and gives you a foolproof manual fallback for the one clip where the automatic match refuses to cooperate.

CHAPTER 7

Rescue It in Post

Editing can't perform miracles — it can't un-clip distortion or un-echo a bad room — but a handful of tools, applied in the right order, turn *good* raw sound into *polished* sound. Here's the processing chain that professionals use, described so you can find each tool in any editor regardless of what the menus call it.

The processing order that works

1 Noise reduction first.

Remove steady background noise — hum, hiss, AC drone. Give the tool a "noise print" from a second of silence, then apply gently. Push it too hard and the voice turns watery and robotic; a light touch is invisible.

2 EQ to shape the voice.

Cut low-end rumble below roughly 80–100 Hz to kill traffic and handling thumps. Then, if the voice sounds dull, add a gentle lift in the *presence* range (around 3–6 kHz) for clarity and articulation.

3 Compression to even it out.

Compression tames the loud parts and lifts the quiet parts so the voice sits at a consistent level — no more leaning in for whispers and flinching at shouts. Aim for gentle, natural evening-out, not a squashed, breathing sound.

4 De-ess if needed.

If "s" and "sh" sounds are harsh and sizzly, a de-esser tames just that narrow high-frequency band without dulling the rest of the voice.

5 Loudness normalization last.

Set the final overall loudness to the platform target so your video isn't jarringly louder or quieter than everything else.

Loudness targets for platforms

Streaming and social platforms measure perceived loudness in **LUFS** (Loudness Units Full Scale) and quietly turn videos up or down toward their own target. Deliver near that target yourself and your sound stays consistent and clean.

Loudness normalization

DELIVERY

Web / social ~-14 LUFS

True peak -1 dBTP

Dialogue-led -16 to -14 LUFS

Around -14 LUFS integrated is a safe modern target for online video. Keep true peaks at -1 dB or below so platform encoding never clips.



Post is polish, not rescue

Every tool here improves clean audio. None of them fixes clipping, heavy reverb, or a voice buried under noise — those are recording problems, and the only real fix is to record them right. Treat post as the last 10%, not the plan.



Print silence for noise reduction

At the top of every recording, capture two seconds of "room tone" — everyone silent, cameras rolling. That clean sample of the room's noise floor is exactly what noise-reduction tools need to learn what to remove, and it's priceless for patching edits later.

CHAPTER 8

Music & Mixing

Music sets mood and energy — and it's where beginners most often bury their own dialogue. The goal of a mix is simple: the viewer never notices the mix. Voice is always clearly on top, music supports underneath, and nothing ever gets a copyright strike.

Set music under dialogue, not over it

The instant a viewer strains to hear words under a track, you've lost them. Voice is the lead; music is the cushion. When someone is speaking, the music should drop well below the voice — quiet enough that you notice it only if it stops.

Music vs. dialogue levels

MIXING

Voice **the star, up front**

Music under speech **~15-20 dB lower**

Music, no speech **bring it up**

A rough guide: under dialogue, music sits far enough below the voice that it never competes. In gaps with no talking, let it swell to fill the space.

Ducking: let the voice push the music down

Rather than riding the music fader by hand, use **ducking** (also called sidechain compression): the music automatically drops whenever the voice is present and rises back up when the voice stops. Set it up once and every dialogue moment stays clear while the music breathes in the gaps — smooth, automatic, professional.



Mix on the ears people will use

Check your final mix on cheap earbuds and a phone speaker, not just good headphones. Most viewers watch on tiny speakers where music masks voice far more easily. If the dialogue is clear on a phone speaker, it's clear everywhere.

Licensing: don't get struck

Using a commercial song you don't have rights to can get your video muted, demonetized, or taken down — and content-matching systems catch it automatically, often within minutes of upload. Protect yourself:



Use royalty-free or properly licensed music libraries made for creators.

- ✓ Read the license: confirm it covers your use (monetized, commercial, the platform you're on).
- ✓ Keep proof — save the license or download receipt in case you need to clear a false claim.
- ✓ "I credited the artist" is not a license. Credit does not grant rights.
- ✓ When unsure, don't use it. One strike isn't worth a track you could have replaced free.



Free to listen is not free to use

A song being on a streaming service, or easy to download, says nothing about your right to put it in a video. Sync rights for video are separate and specific. Assume every commercial song is off-limits unless a license explicitly says otherwise.

CHAPTER 9

The Field Audio Checklist

Tape this inside your bag. Run it before every shoot, before the moment you can't recreate. Ninety seconds here saves a ruined recording.

Before you hit record

- ☒ Right mic for the job — lav on a mover, shotgun for a scene, USB at the desk.
- ☒ Mic as close to the mouth as the shot allows, angled at the mouth.
- ☒ Lav clipped where fabric won't rustle; cable strain-relieved and hidden.
- ☒ Windscreen or dead-cat on outdoor mics; check for wind on the meter.
- ☒ Room checked with a clap; softened it if it rang.
- ☒ Levels set from a real test line — peaks landing around -12 to -6 dBFS.
- ☒ Auto-gain / auto-levels turned OFF; gain set manually.
- ☒ Headphones plugged into the recording device, mic confirmed audible through them.
- ☒ Batteries charged and storage space confirmed on recorder and wireless kit.
- ☒ Two seconds of room tone captured for later noise reduction.
- ☒ Camera scratch track rolling as a sync reference and backup.
- ☒ Clap or slate at the top of the take.

While rolling

- ☒ Eyes flick to the meters — nothing kissing 0 dBFS.
- ☒ Ears on the headphones — no dropouts, buzzes, rustle, or new noise.
- ☒ Listen for the AC, fridge, or phone buzz that kicked on mid-take.



Your drill this week

Record the same 20-second line four ways: camera mic across the room, camera mic up close, an external mic at arm's length, and that same mic six inches away. Listen back on headphones. You will hear, unmistakably, that distance beats gear — and you'll never again wonder why your sound is thin.

REMEMBER

Get the right mic close, kill the room, watch your levels in headphones — do those three things and your sound will already be better than most of what people scroll past.

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